

Voluntary Report – Voluntary - Public Distribution

Date: June 13, 2025

Report Number: BU2025-0012

Report Name: Oilseeds and Products Market Update

Country: Bulgaria

Post: Sofia

Report Category: Oilseeds and Products

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Report Highlights:

Prospects for marketing year (MY) 2025/26 oilseed crops in Bulgaria are currently positive due to favorable weather and larger planted area. FAS/Sofia estimates the MY 2025/26 rapeseed crop at 240,000 metric tons (MT) and the sunflower crop at 2.0 million metric tons (MMT). However, there is potential for even further increases in average yields and production for rapeseed compared to last year if favorable weather continues until the harvest starts in June. Expectations for the sunflower crop are highly dependent on the summer weather in July/August but are for a recovery, following a record low crop in MY 2024/25.

Weather Overview

The spring weather was generally satisfactory for oilseed crops, resulting in a positive yield outlook. Overall, moderate temperatures and sufficient rainfall provided favorable conditions, despite a cold spell in early April and lower-than-usual temperatures around mid-May. The unusual cold spell in early-mid April brought snowfall and freezing temperatures, mainly affecting some blossoming rapeseed fields. Abundant rainfall at the end of May improved the soil moisture levels, offering fair conditions for yield formation (Maps 1-3, 4, and 5). As of early June, the rapeseed crop shows above-average biomass accumulation.

The planting of sunflower started late due to cold weather and wet topsoils in the first half of April. Since then, however, warmer-than-usual temperatures have allowed field work to accelerate under suitable soil conditions and to compensate for the delay. As of early June, the planting is close to completion. Shorter cold spells in late April and mid May delayed emergence and slowed down early development of newly planted sunflower. Soil moisture conditions are optimal except in parts of northwestern Bulgaria. The NDVI index is similar to that in 2024 and above the average (Graph 6) and crop conditions are positive as of early June. ([JRC MARS Bulletin May Vol 33 №4](#), [Crop Explorer](#) and [Bulgaria data](#)). (See Maps 1-7 and Graph 3 in the Appendix).

MY 2025/26

The Ministry of Agriculture made public statements that the expected winter crops will be “very good” since more than 90 percent of the fields are in good-to-excellent condition. The European Commission’s (EC) latest forecasts for Bulgaria ([JRC MARS Bulletin May Vol 33 №4](#)), show rapeseed yields at 2.58 MT/HA, three percent above the five-year average and five percent more than in MY 2024/25; and sunflower yields at 2.14 MT/HA, two percent above the five-year average and 23 percent higher than in MY 2024/25.

Farmers made efforts to maximize both the rapeseed and sunflower crop area due to expected good profitability. According to the latest Ministry of Agriculture [data](#) (as of May 15), rapeseed area grew by 51 percent to 97,340 HA compared to 64,260 HA in MY 2024/25 (Table 1). This is still below the area planted in the fall (102,000 HA, Ministry of Agriculture [data](#), as of the end of December 2024), due to some reseeding after winter, and as a result of early April cold/snow spell.

Expanded area and favorable weather are expected to support good rapeseed yields; however, fertilizer and plant protection input application have been mixed among producers due to their growing prices. For this reason, current FAS/Sofia estimates are for stable average yields compared to MY 2024/25 at 2.5 MT/HA and production at 240,000 MT, 50 percent more than in MY 2024/25, due to the increase in area. Nevertheless, the current yield potential is very good, and this may lead to further growth in MY 2025/26 yields and production despite uneven input applications if the favorable weather continues to support the final stages of crop development. Industry estimates for the upcoming rapeseed harvest vary from 220,000 MT to 300,000 MT.

For most producers growing sunflower was more attractive than growing corn as it is more resilient to summer weather risks and more cost-efficient, and domestic crush demand remains strong. However,

due to the increase in wheat and rapeseed planted area last fall, and to crop rotation requirements, area planted under sunflower may not have a significant potential for growth this season. Sunflower planting is still ongoing and planted area as of May 29 is reported by the authorities at 863,000 HA, still 10.7 percent behind the planted area at this point last season. FAS/Sofia projects that sunflower area will likely be only slightly higher than last year at around 950,000 HA compared to 929,000 HA in MY 2024/25 (Table 1). Industry estimates vary from 930,000 HA to 990,000 HA.

In the last three years, Bulgaria suffered from extreme hot and dry summer weather in July and August that negatively affected the sunflower crop and had a strong impact on yields, production, and farm income. Currently, the newly planted sunflower is in good condition due to favorable climate, however, weather risks later in the season remain. Currently, FAS/Sofia forecasts an average yield of 2.1 MT/HA and production at 2.0 MMT, 25 percent more than in the last season. Private estimates for sunflower yields range from 2.1 MT/HA to 2.3 MT/HA, compared to exceptionally low 1.77 MT/HA last year, with respective production projected in the range of 1.9 MMT to 2.3 MMT compared to 1.6 MMT in MY 2024/25.

MY 2024/25 Final Production Estimates and Domestic Demand

Please see updated official production data/Eurostat in Table 1.

Rapeseed Crush:

Domestic rapeseed crush has strengthened significantly due to the expansion of crushing facilities for biodiesel. In addition, crush margins have been better for rapeseed compared to those for sunflower seeds during most of the season. This has caused sunflower crushers to increasingly switch from sunflower seed to rapeseed crush.

According to Ministry of Agriculture data, rapeseed crush as of May 30 increased sharply to 411,000 MT, 112 percent more than a year ago (193,000 MT). This is also more than the annual MY 2023/24 crush, estimated at 230,000 MT. Most of the rapeseeds crushed have been sourced from imports. Per the Ministry of Agriculture data, MY 2024/25 imports of rapeseed as of end of May were at 459,000 MT, 152 percent more than imports in the corresponding period a year ago and above industry expectations (Table 2). Imports are sourced mainly from Romania, Moldova, and Canada. Conversely, exports are at 90,000 MT, compared to 130,000 MT exported a year ago (Table 2). As a result of the elevated crush, exports of processed products (rapeseed oil and meal) are also expanding from MY 2023/24.

Due to higher imports and lower exports, and despite the increase in crush, the available stocks at the end of May are reported 21 percent higher than a year ago at 126,000 MT. This is expected to support a growth in trade and/or crush in the new season, especially with the expectation for a larger crop in MY 2025/26.

Sunflower Crush:

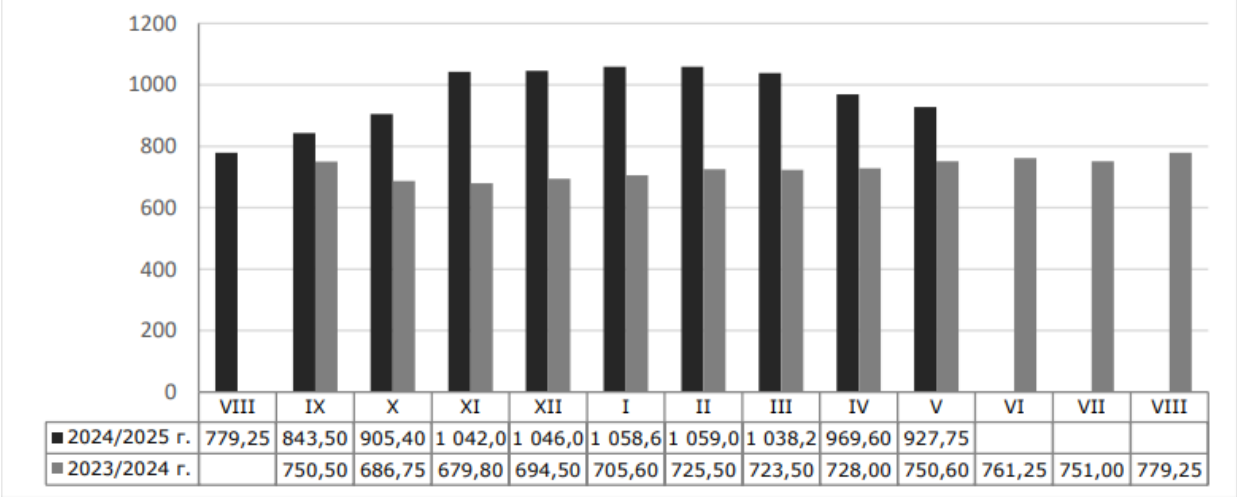
With limited domestic sunflower seeds, demand for imports has been strong. Crushers have made every effort to source price-competitive sunflower seeds both from domestic producers and from imports. As a result, imports increased and as of the end of May, imports reached 686,000 MT (Table 2) or 49 percent more than a year ago (459,000 MT). They were sourced from Romania, Moldova, Serbia, and Ukraine. Thanks to growing imports, the sunflower crush, which had a low period earlier in the marketing year due to the poor margins and the deficit market, managed to almost recover; as of May 30, sunflower

crush was reported at 1.31 MMT or only five percent lower than the level seen last year. As a result of the stabilizing crush, exports of processed products (sunflower oil and meal) are also growing.

In addition, demand for sunflower de-hulling/processing has been more active and the quantity of sunflower seeds used for de-hulling as of the end of May was 24 percent more than a year ago. As a result, total domestic use of sunflower seeds (crush and de-hulling) grew modestly to 1.74 MMT compared to 1.72 MMT a year ago.

Farm-gate sunflower seed prices have increased, exceeding the levels seen in the previous year (Graph 1). In May, sunflower prices were 24 percent higher than a year ago, reflecting the local decline in the crop and the deficit market. Nevertheless, many farmers have been reluctant sellers while crushers began to rely on imported sunflower or to switch to imported rapeseed. This is leading to unusually high ending stocks of sunflower seeds at the farm level. As of the end of May, stocks are reported 62 percent more than in MY 2023/24 (681,000 MT).

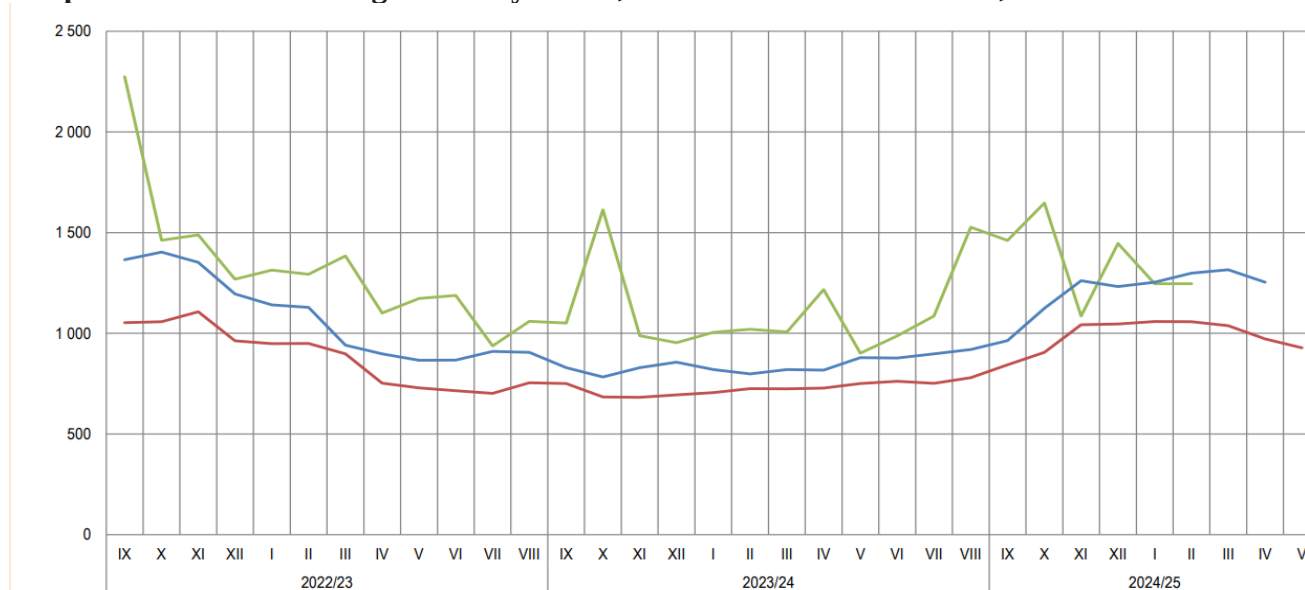
Graph 1. Sunflower Monthly Market Prices, MY 2024/25 vs MY 2023/24 in BGN/MT (May 2025)



*The chart shows prices for the MY, which begins in September, with MY 2024/25 in dark black and MY 2023/24 in grey. The graph also includes August due to early harvest in 2024 when most of the sunflower crop was harvested and began to be traded.

Source: Bulgarian Ministry of Agriculture Monitoring of Commodity Markets Weekly Bulletins

Graph 2. Sunflower Average Monthly Prices, MY 2022/23 – MY 2024/25, BGN/MT



Red line- Bulgarian ex-farm prices, sunflower seeds, in Bulgarian leva (BGN) per MT

Blue line – EU export price FOB Bordeaux, sunflower seeds, BGN/MT

Green line – Bulgarian CIF export price, sunflower seeds, BGN/MT

Source: Bulgarian Ministry of Agriculture [Dashboard](#) Grains and Oilseeds, June 2025

Appendix:

Table 1. Oilseed Crops Final Production Data MY 2024/25 and MY 2023/24, June 2025

Crops	Area Harvested (000 HA)		Production (000 MT)	
	MY 2024/25	MY 2023/24	MY 2024/25	MY 2023/24
Rapeseed	64.26	79.79	159.87	207.04
Sunflower	929.08	869.92	1644.81	1783.99
Soybeans	0.58	3.67	0.63	6.07
Total	993.92	953.38	1,805.31	1,997.1

Source: Eurostat data based on EU standard moisture content- updated as of June 2025

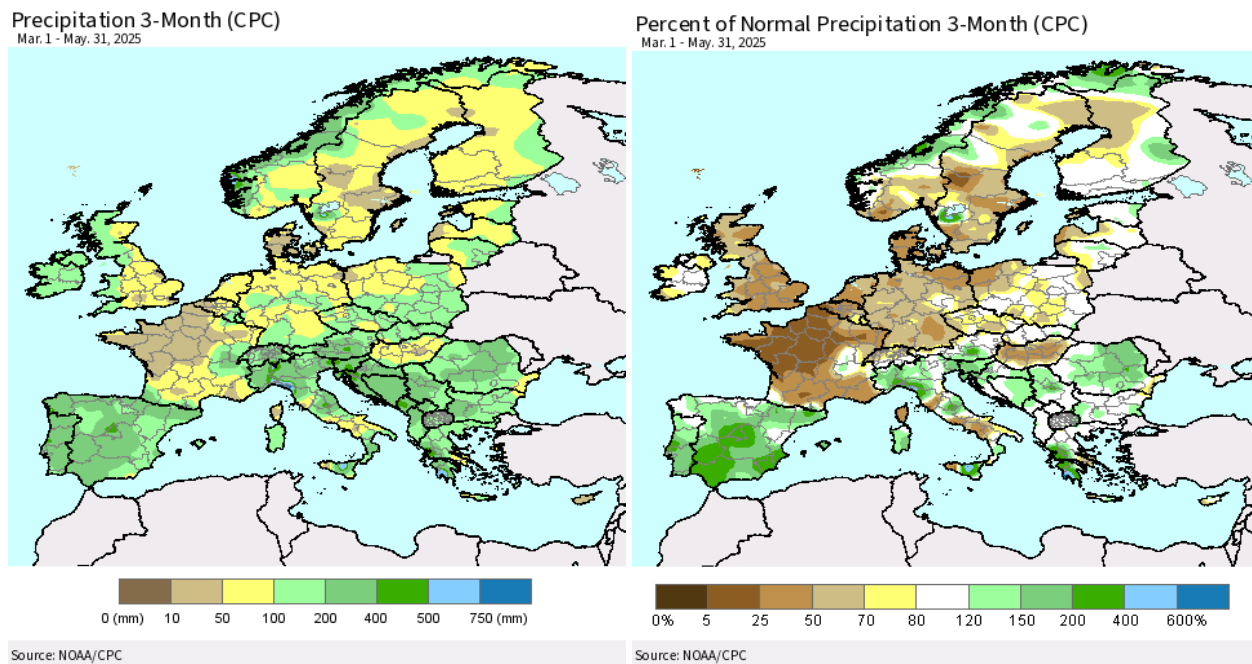
Table 2: Trade in Major Oilseed Crops, as of May 30, 2025

Types of Oilseeds	Imports, MT	Exports, MT
Rapeseed, MY 2024/25	458,712 MT	89,541 MT (86,341 MT for the EU market and 3,200 MT for non-EU markets)
Sunflower, MY 2024/25	685,973 MT	223,377 MT (47,645 MT for the EU market and 175,732 MT for non-EU markets)

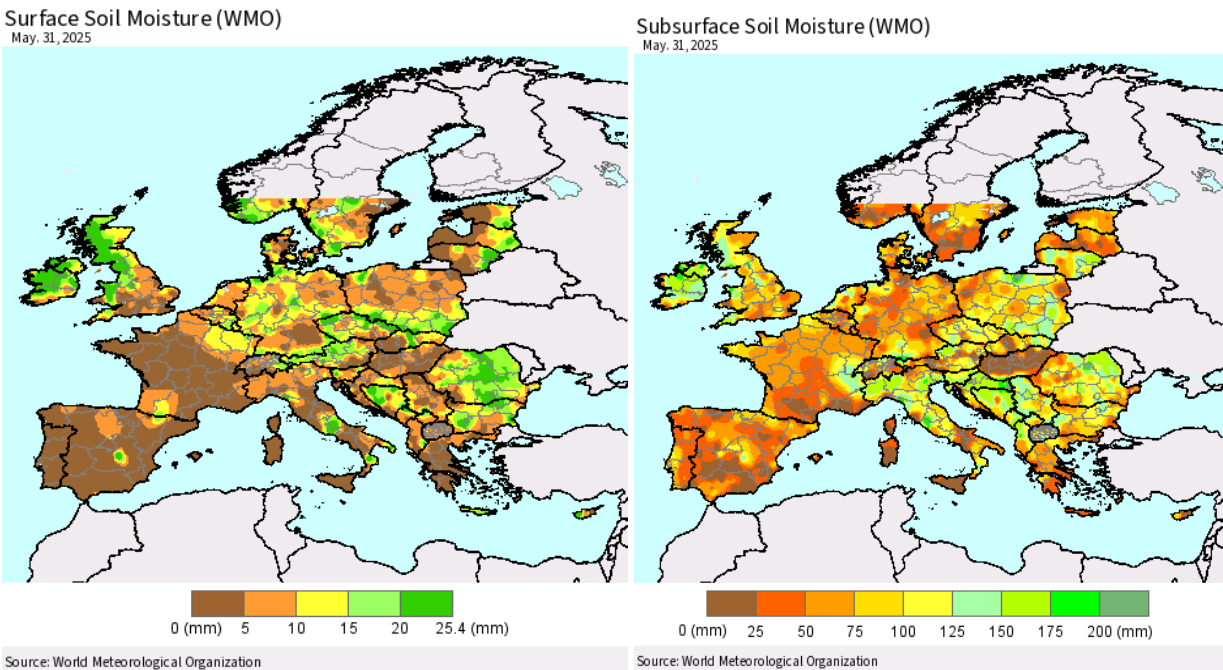
Source: Ministry of Agriculture weekly bulletins;

Note: The Bulgarian Ministry of Agriculture uses September 1-August 31 as a MY for sunflower.

Map 1: USDA [Crop Explorer](#), Europe (including Bulgaria), Precipitation and Percent of Normal Precipitation, March 1 to June 1, 2025.

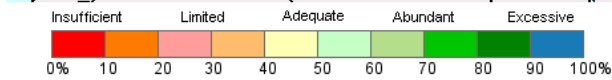
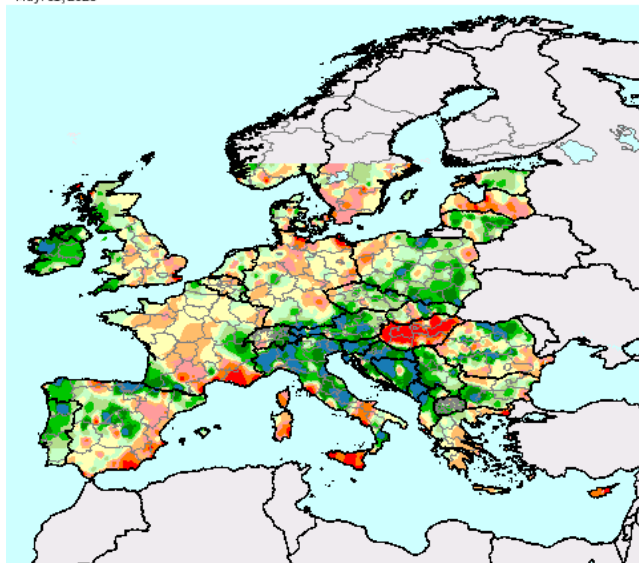


Map 2: USDA Crop Explorer, Europe (including Bulgaria), Surface and Subsurface Soil Moisture; Percent of Soil Moisture and Soil Moisture Ranking as of May 31, 2025



Percent Soil Moisture (WMO)

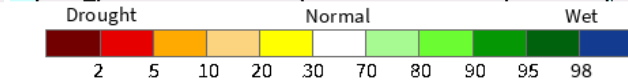
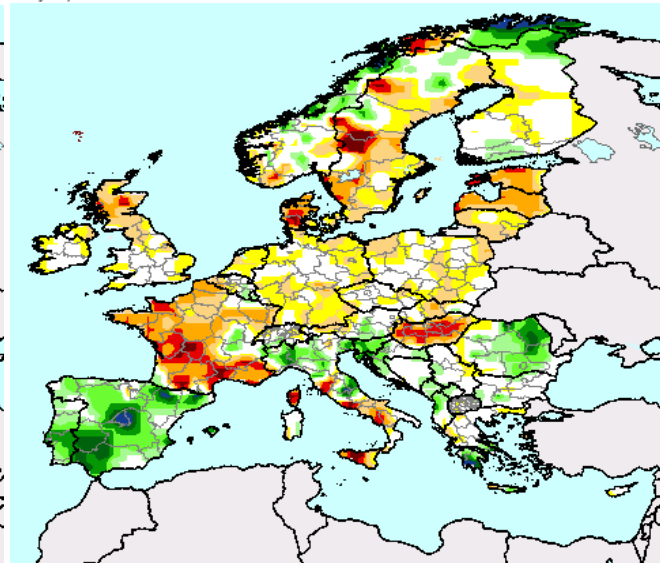
May. 31, 2025



Source: World Meteorological Organization

CPC Soil Moisture Ranking Percentile (Leaky Bucket)

May. 31, 2025

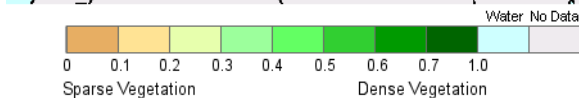
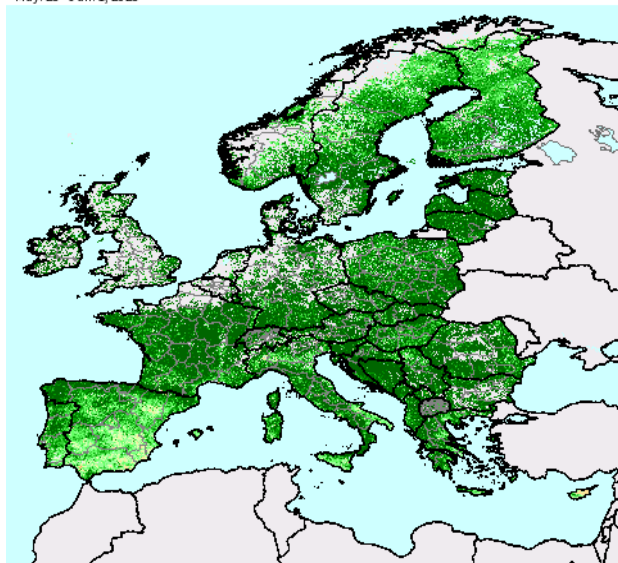


Source: NOAA/CPC

Map 3. USDA Crop Explorer, Europe (including Bulgaria), NDVI (Vegetation Index) for May 25-June 1, 2025 and NDVI Departure from the Previous Year

NDVI (Terra-MODIS)

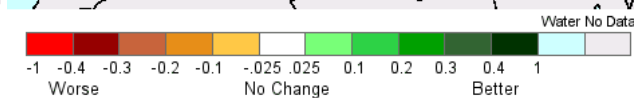
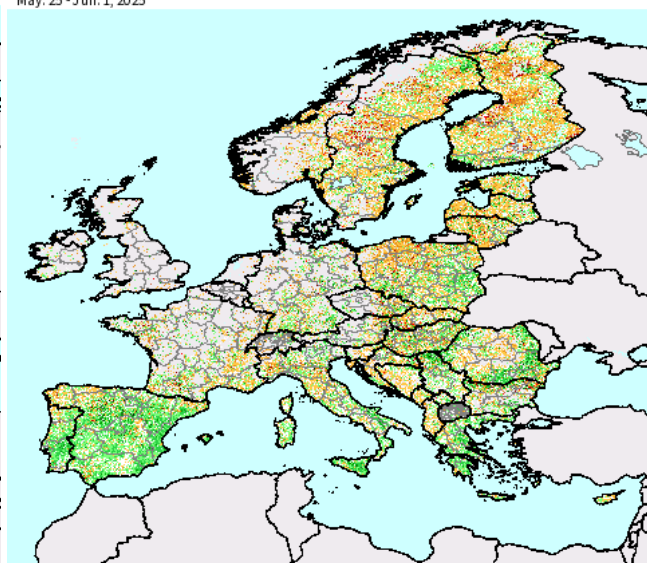
May. 25 - Jun. 1, 2025



Source: NDVI MODIS-Terra at 250-m

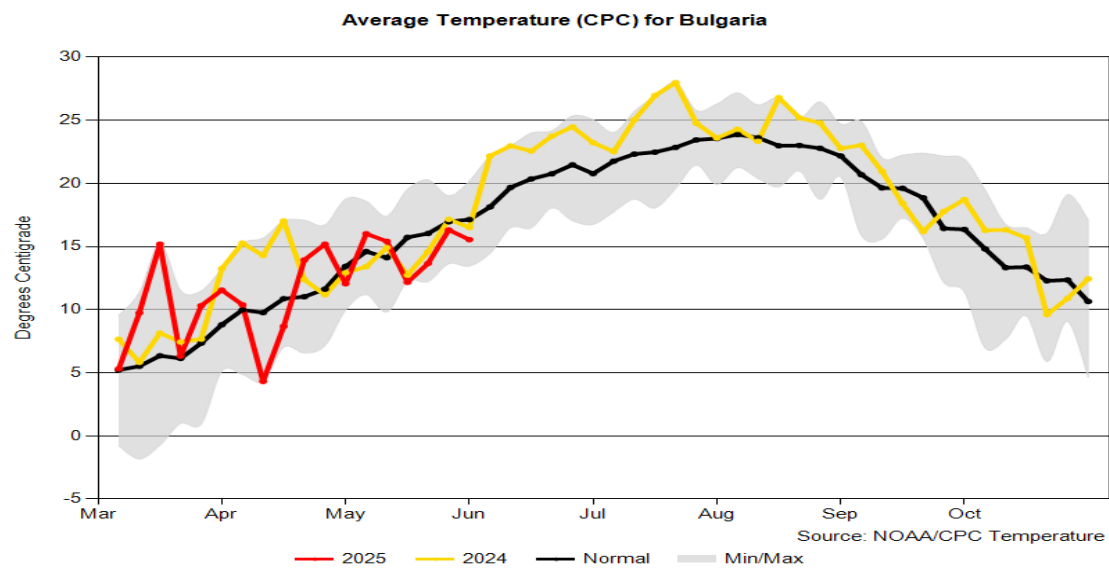
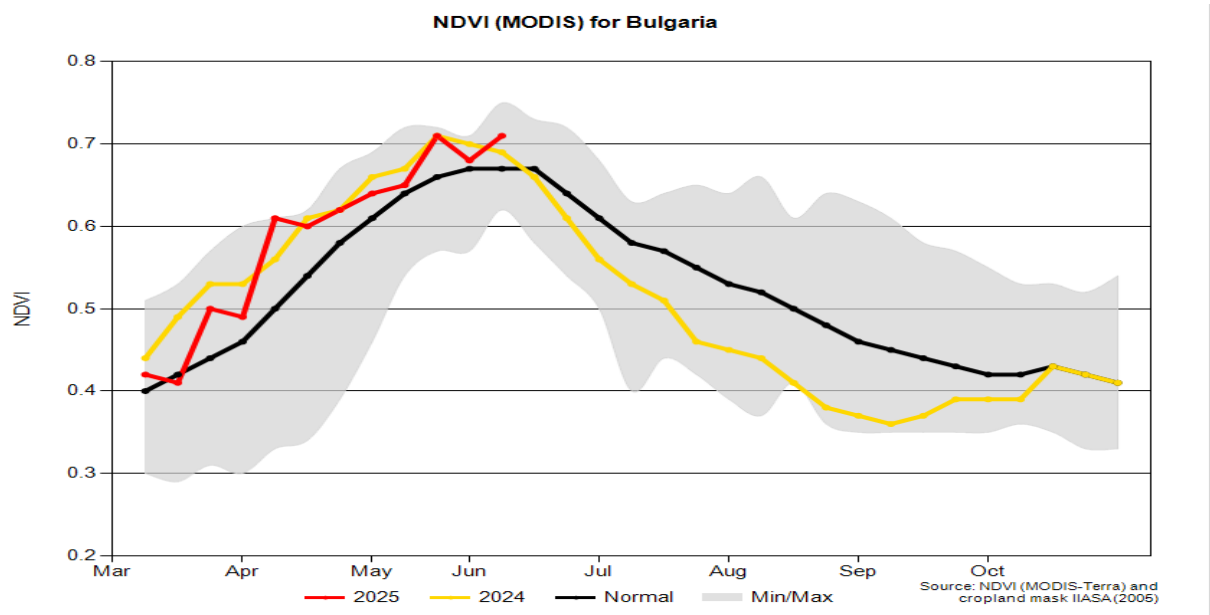
NDVI Departure from Previous Year (Terra-MODIS)

May. 25 - Jun. 1, 2025

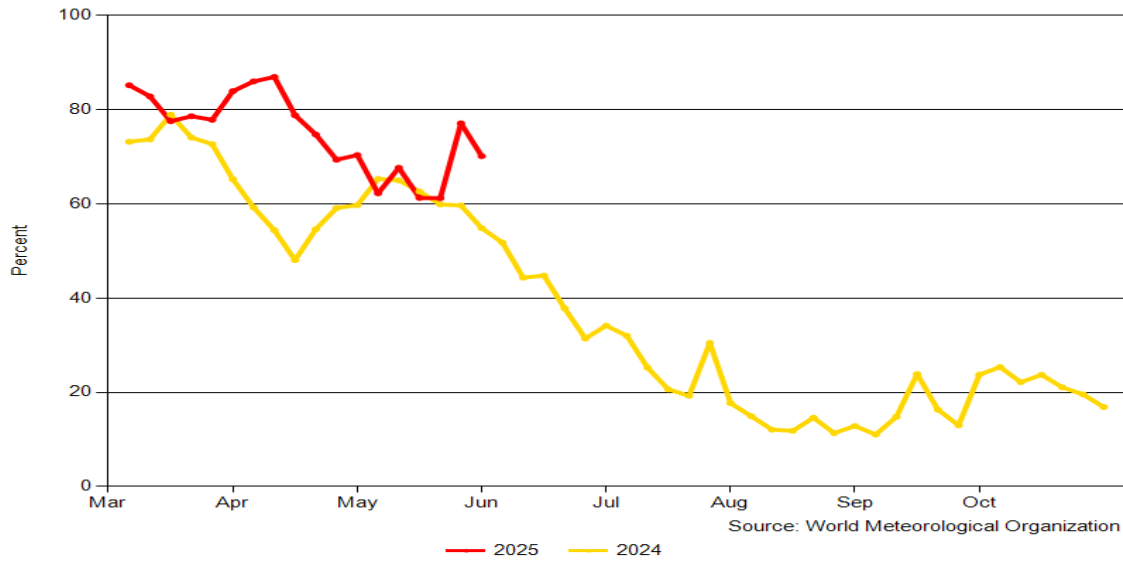


Source: NDVI MODIS-Terra at 250-m

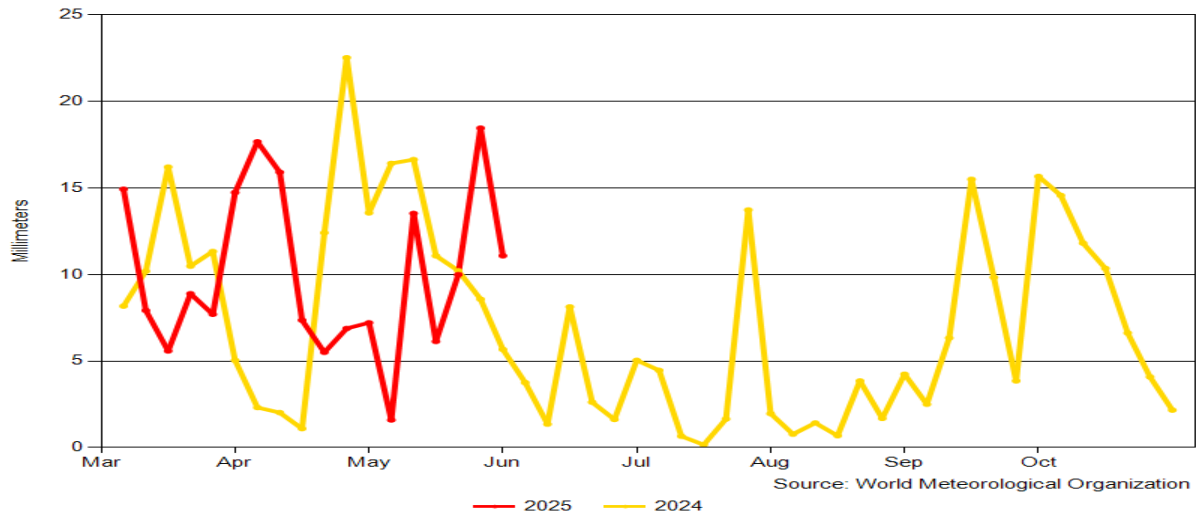
Graph 3. USDA [Crop Explorer](#), Bulgaria, Vegetation Index (NDVI), Average Temperature, Percent of Soil Moisture, Surface and Subsurface Soil Moisture, as of February 17, 2025



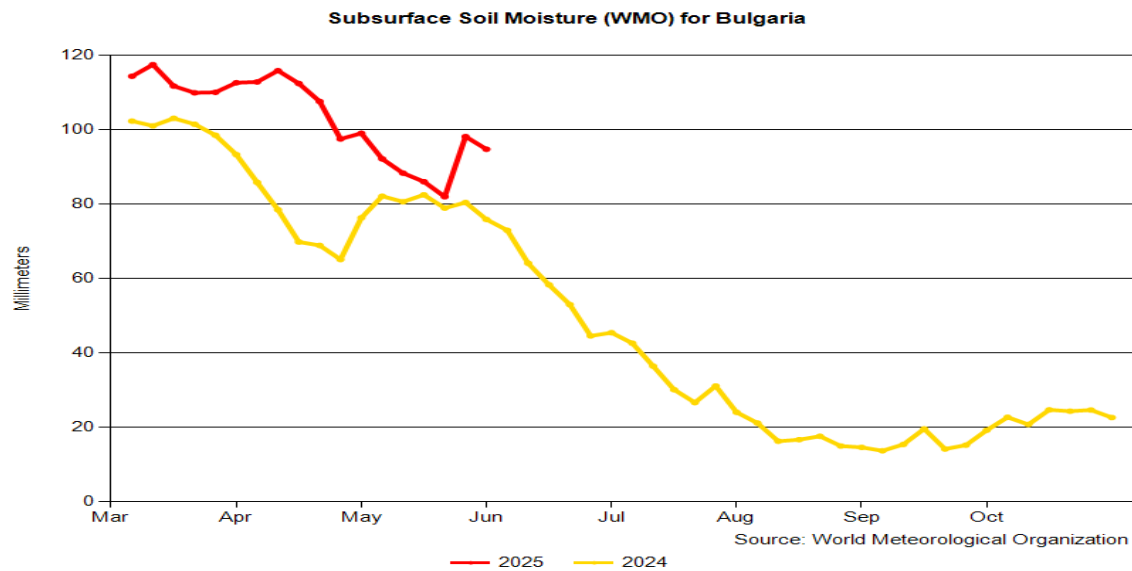
Percent Soil Moisture (WMO) for Bulgaria



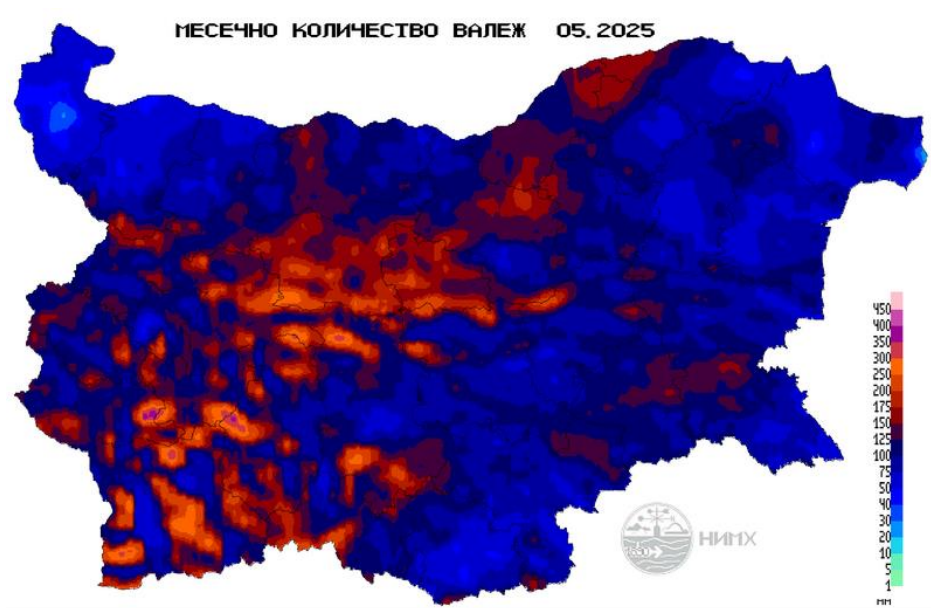
Surface Soil Moisture (WMO) for Bulgaria



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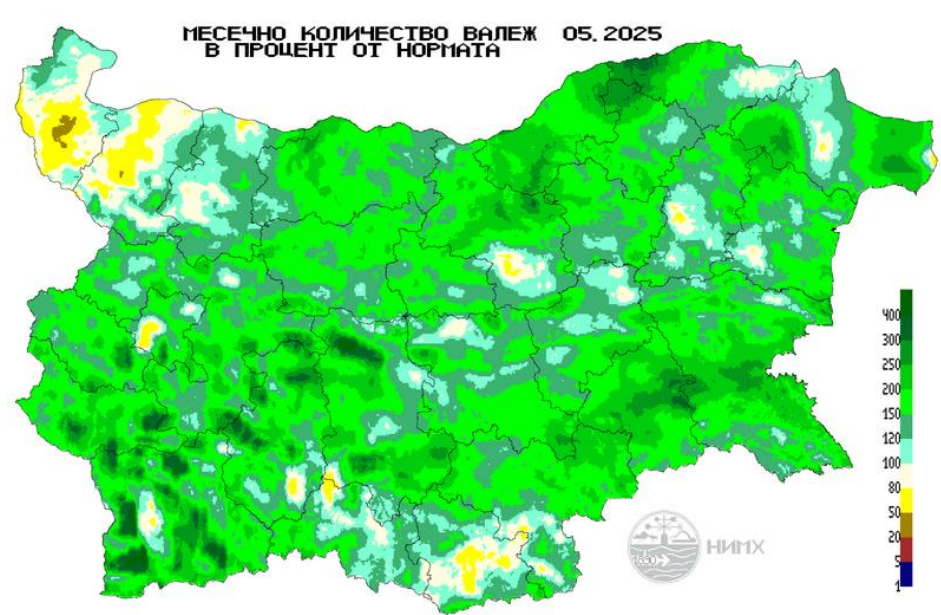


Map 4. May Rainfall 2025



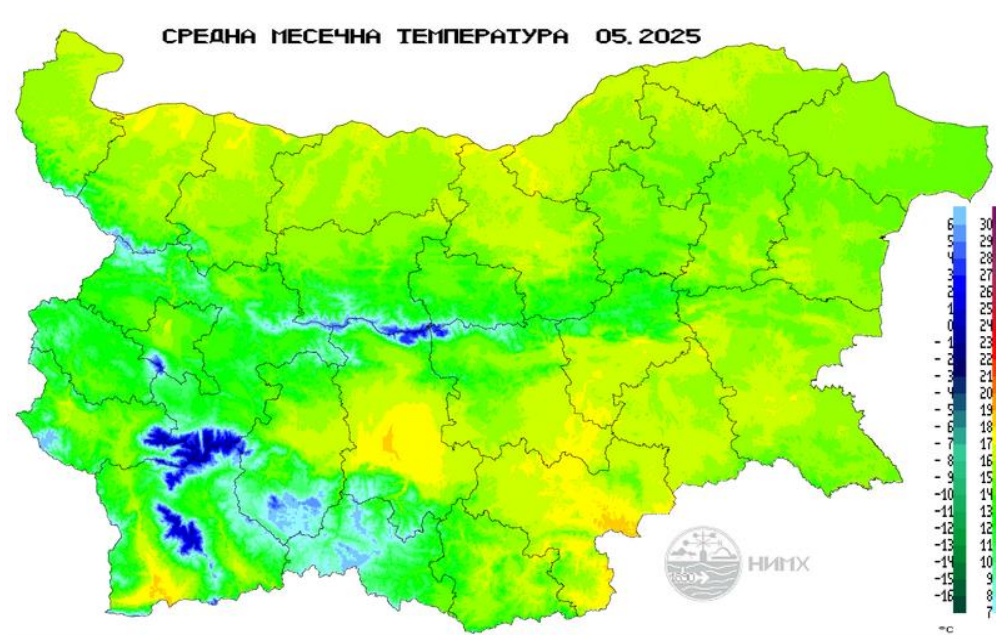
Source: [Bulgarian National Institute of Meteorology and Hydrology](#)

Map 5. May Rainfall 2025 as a percent of Monthly Norm



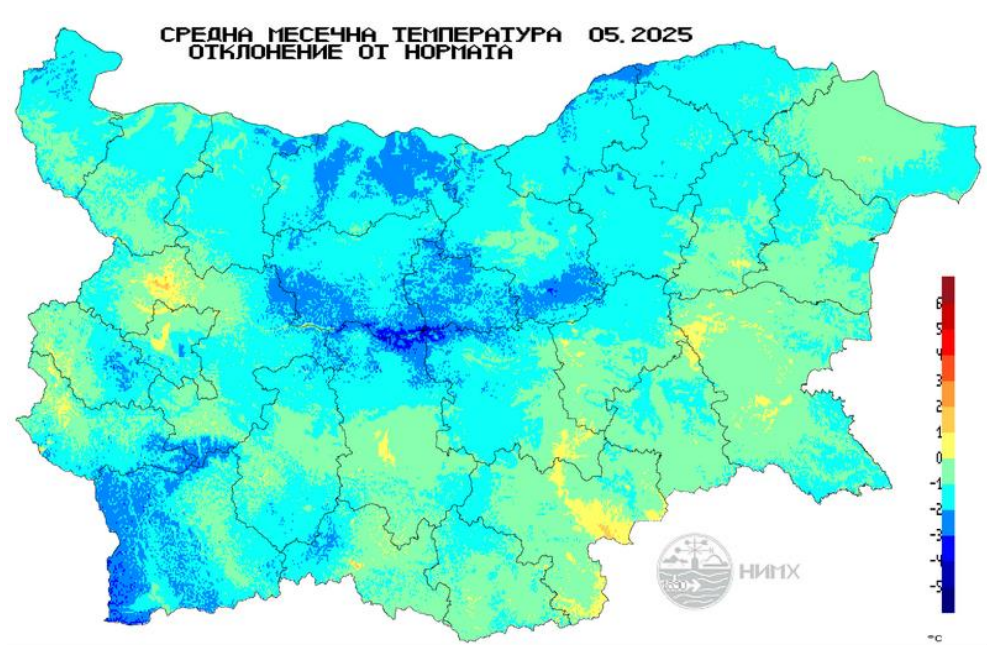
Source: [Bulgarian National Institute of Meteorology and Hydrology](#)

Map 6. Average Temperature May 2025



Source: [Bulgarian National Institute of Meteorology and Hydrology](#)

Map 7: May 2025: Deviation from the Average Temperature Norm



Source: [Bulgarian National Institute of Meteorology and Hydrology](#)

Attachments:

No Attachments.